

A THIRD RECKONING, KEYED AND READY TO RUN

BLOOD & GRIT

A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF THE HAUNTED
FRONTIER

WHAT THE WATER ANSWERS

Module III · A one-night adventure for four souls at 5th level · Version 1.3

The water is going bad from the bottom up, and the mission knows why.





"They did not build the mission over the well. They built the well first and put the mission on top of it, the way you put a hand on a lid."

— FRAY IGNACIO SALCEDO, SAN CLAVO, UNDATED



"A binding is not a thing you did. It is a thing you are doing. The day you stop is the day it was never done at all."

— THE LAST FULL ENTRY IN THE PADRES' LEDGER



Blood & Grit · Module III · What the Water Answers · Version 1.3 · For the Keeper Alone

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What This Is



Everything in this county drinks from the same hole in the ground. Remember that when they ask you why it is their business.

— A NOTE PINNED INSIDE THE COVER OF THE FIRST PRINTING



One night at the table, for four souls at 5th level, at Mission San Clavo and under it. Four hours, and it will want the whole four. Every creature in it is printed here in full, so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf.

This is the third of three and the only one that goes into the mission. Module I ends at its east wall. Module II ends forty miles north of it. Perdition Basin has been pointing at San Clavo since the Keeper's Book Ch. XIII, and everything the two earlier nights left unexplained is in a hole under its floor.

It does not require either of the others. It is better after both.

What You Need

The Player's Book for the souls, and this. The Keeper's Book Ch. XIII is genuinely useful here and still not required; what a Keeper needs from it is on The Truth of It. If you are running GritKeeper, put the clock on the Tracker before Act One begins and let the table watch it fill.

What It Teaches, and in What Order

Three things, one per act, and never two at once.

- **Act One teaches that the country is the victim.** A well, a family, and three things that drank from it. A fight a 5th-level posse wins.
- **Act Two teaches that somebody wrote it down.** The padres kept a ledger of what they bound and what keeping it cost, and the last entry stops mid-word. The fight in the nave is the one this module lets go badly: the engine cleared it three times in nine.
- **Act Three teaches what a binding actually is.** Not a thing done once. A thing being done, by somebody, continuously, until they stop. The posse goes down the shaft to find out who stopped, and then has to decide whether to start again.

BEFORE YOU RUN IT

Read the ledger entries in Act Two aloud, slowly, in order. They are the module's whole argument and they are short on purpose. Everything else here can be improvised; those cannot, because the last one has to land.

The Truth of It

For the Keeper alone. Two people in the module know a piece of this. Nobody alive knows all of it.

In 1809 the padres of San Clavo found something at the bottom of the first well they dug, which is the only reason there is a mission here at all. They did not destroy it. Fray Ignacio Salcedo, who wrote most of the ledger, is explicit that they could not, and unusually clear-eyed about what they did instead: they pinned it. Seven wells across the Basin, each with a nail of worked silver driven at the waterline, each blessed, each renewed by hand on a schedule.

The mission burned in 1811 and the order went home. One man stayed, and then one man after him, and then one after that: seventy years of a single person walking a circuit of seven wells with a hammer and a prayer, telling almost nobody, because the ledger says plainly that a thing widely known is a thing eventually dug up.

The Last Keeper of It

Esperanza Ríos died in her sleep in April, eighty-one years old, four miles from here, and told nobody. She had been walking the circuit alone for thirty-one years. She meant to hand it on and she kept meaning to, the way a person does. There is no villain in this module and the module should not go looking for one.

What Is Failing, and in What Order

Four months without renewal. The nails are giving in the order they were driven, which is the order of the wells outward from the mission, which means the failures have been walking toward the towns and away from the thing all summer. Three have gone. The Cardoza well went eleven days ago and is where Act One opens.

What comes up first is not the thing. It is the water: bad, and then wrong, and then busy. The ones who drink it drown standing up, in air, months later, and get up afterward.

The Clock

The Wells, Failing Outward

6 segments



Three segments are already filled when the module opens: three nails gone. Fill one each time the posse spends a night elsewhere, and one when they open the shaft. At six the first well fails, which is the one directly over it, which is the one they are standing on in Act Three.

KEEPER

Show the clock. Put it on the table with three pips already inked and do not explain it until Act Two. A clock the players can see and cannot read is the best pressure this system has, and this module is the one that earns it.

The Hook, and Getting Them There

Calvary Crossing has been drinking hauled water for nine days and paying for it. The man who hauls it will not go back to the Cardoza place, and he will not say why in front of his wife, and he will say it for two dollars out back by the wagon.

The posse is being hired to look at a well. That is all. It should sound like the least dangerous work anybody has offered them all year, and a table coming off module II will be suspicious of exactly how boring it sounds, which is fine and even useful.

Three Ways In

- **Paid.** Calvary Crossing wants its water back and will pay forty dollars for somebody to tell them why they cannot have it.
- **Following module I.** The scrap of worked silver off Tom Pell's body is a piece of a nail. Anyone who kept it will find it warm to the hand within a mile of the mission, and cold at the wells that have already failed.
- **Following module II.** The Skin-Walker was buying old church silver up and down the north line and paying too much for it. It had a list. The list is a list of wells.

Elías Cardoza, who owns the well

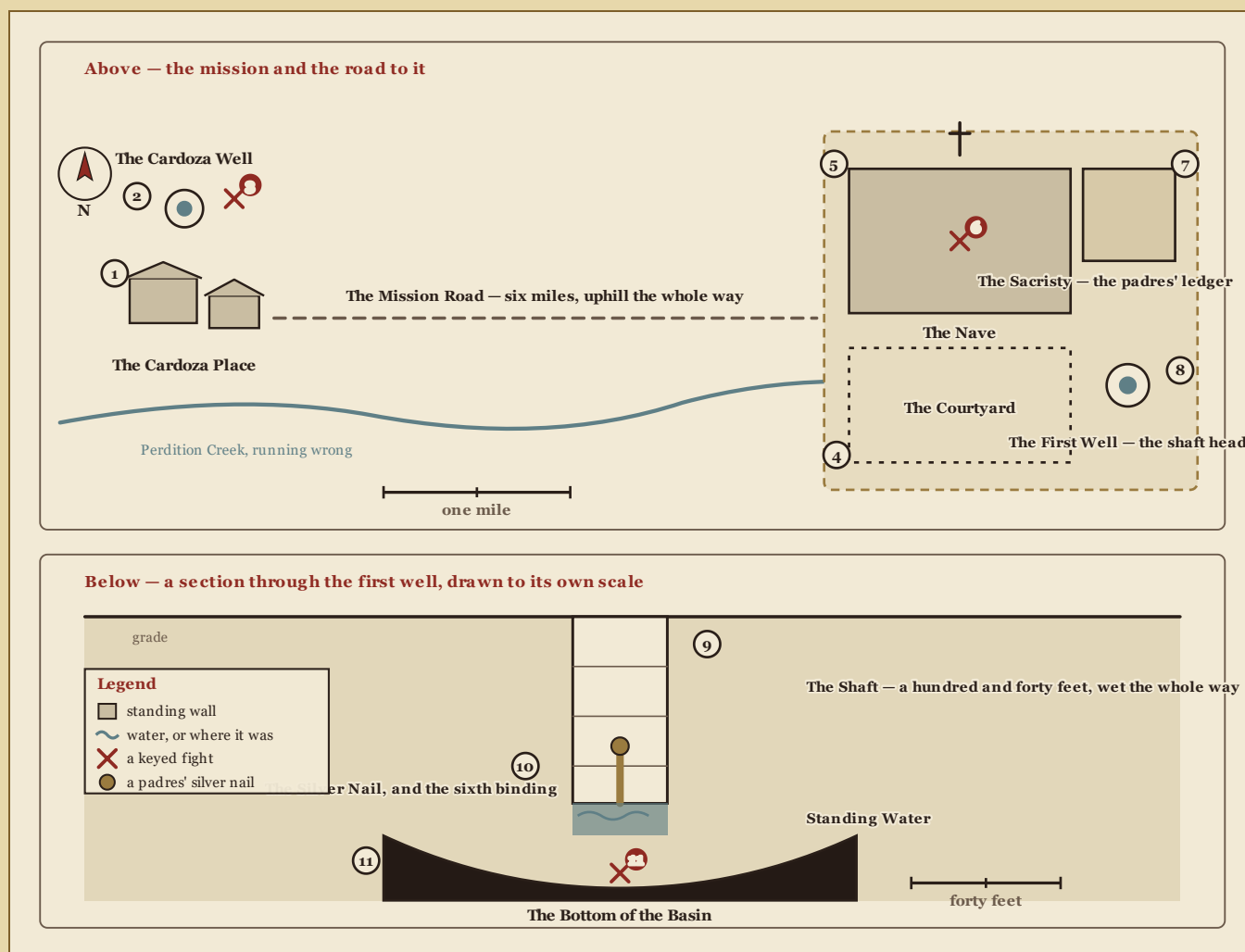
WANTS his family to stop being sick and his water to stop being wrong

LEVER he buried two of his own eleven days ago and did not dig deep, because the ground was wet and he was tired

"It is a well. It has been a well for forty years. Tell me what a well can be."

The Ground

Every numbered place below is a keyed scene, and the number on the map is the number in the margin of the act it belongs to. The map is drawn in two panels because the last act happens under the first one.



*Mission San Clavo, Above and Below — the mission and the road to it above, and a section through the first well below, with the eleven
keyed scenes pinned where they happen*

What the Shape of It Does

Two panels, two scales, and the second one is the point. The upper panel is six miles of open country and a ruin on a rise, the country the posse has spent two modules riding across. The lower panel is a hundred and forty feet straight down, drawn to its own scale, and it will not fit on the same drawing as the first because it is not that kind of distance.

- **The mission is uphill from everything.** Which is why its well was dug first, and why every other well in the Basin is downstream of whatever is in it.
- **The shaft is wet the whole way.** There is no dry descent and no clever route. Whatever the posse brings down, it brings down soaked.
- **The bottom is wider than the shaft.** That is not a drawing error. The padres did not dig the bottom.

KEEPER

Show the table the upper panel in Act One and cover the lower one with your hand. Uncover it when somebody looks down the wellhead in Act Three. The download beside the map prints both panels on one sheet, so you can cut it if you would rather.

Act One – What Comes Up With the Water

Aim for an hour. One Dread Check, one fight the posse should win.

1. The Cardoza Place

Adobe, forty years old, four miles east of Calvary Crossing on the mission road. Eleven people lived here in the spring. Six do now. Two are buried out back in ground that will not stay dry and three have gone to relatives and are not coming home.

Elías Cardoza will let them look at anything and answer anything. He is not hiding a thing and he has not got a thing to hide, and a posse two modules deep in this country will spend twenty minutes establishing that, which is time well spent.

2. The Cardoza Well

Dread Check, DC 16, Will save. Tier II loss. Not for anything that moves. For what the bucket brings up.

The water is clear. That is the first wrong thing: it has been clear for eleven days in a well nobody can drink from. The second wrong thing is in the bottom of the bucket, under the water, lying flat: a hand's worth of long dark hair, and it is clean, and it is combed.

Anyone who goes down on the rope finds the waterline, and at the waterline finds a socket cut square into the stone, four inches deep, empty, and greened at the edges where something silver sat in it for seventy years.

KEEPER

Plant the socket and move on. Do not explain it. The posse will see six more of them before the night is out and the seventh is the one that matters. If somebody in the party is carrying the silver scrap from module I, let it go cold in their hand at the wellhead, once, and say nothing about it.

3. The Ones Who Drank First

The two Cardoza graves are not what is coming. What is coming is the three who went to relatives, who are back, and who arrive up the road at dusk on foot, together, walking well.

SIGN OF IT. River fords and bends, mill-ponds, flooded mines, the slack water below a dam. Wherever someone drowned and was never properly buried, the water remembers.

Full entry under What Is Coming Up. Three of them. They are wet to the waist in a dry country and they have been walking two days.

KEEPER

The engine says the posse wins this: nine clears in twelve, about three rounds. It is meant to be won. What it is not meant to be is free: the fight is in the dooryard of a family that is watching, and two of the three are recognised on sight by somebody standing behind the posse.

The Walk to the Mission

Six miles, uphill, on bad water, and the module charges for it: **3 Blood from each soul, no save**, unless they thought to haul clean water from the Crossing. Nobody will have. Charge it once, say what it feels like, and do not make it a scene.

Act Two – The Ledger of the Padres

Aim for ninety minutes. One Dread Check, one fight that can go wrong, and the whole answer written down in somebody else's hand.

4. The Courtyard

Roofless since 1811. Grass in the flags, a fig tree that should not be alive, and the well the posse is going to end the night in, capped with a cut stone somebody has been keeping clear of brush. Recently. Within the year.

That detail is the module's first honest clue and the best one: somebody has been *maintaining* this ruin, and stopped four months ago.

5. The Nave

Three walls, no roof, and the carved panels module I sends its posse to read are on the east wall of this room. If your table played that night, let them recognise the carvings from across the floor, and let that be the first time this campaign has handed them something for free.

6. What Has Been Living in the Nave

Under the fallen roof timbers at the west end, where the rain collects. They have been here since the spring and they are what happens when the water gets into people who were already dead.

SIGN OF IT. The cemeteries and trench-graves of a town that took a hard epidemic, especially one buried in a panic. Fouled wells, sickrooms left as they were, the abandoned pest-house at the edge of a played-out settlement.

Full entry under What Is Coming Up. Three of them, and this is the fight this module lets go badly: three clears in nine on the engine. See What the Night Costs before you run it, because the reason is not the creature.

KEEPER

Fight it in the rubble. Broken ground, standing water, and a roof timber that will come down on somebody if it is shot through. A posse that treats this like the dooryard fight in Act One will find out why the numbers are worse.

7. The Sacristy, and the Ledger

The one room in the mission with a roof on it, because somebody has kept a roof on it. Dry, swept, and holding a chest, a hammer, a whetstone, four blanks of unworked silver, and the ledger.

Read these aloud, in order, as they are found. They are the module.

1809, in Salcedo's hand. "We have not killed it and I will not write that we have. We have put a nail in it and we will keep putting nails in it. Whoever reads this after me: the work is not the nail. The work is the returning."

1834, a different hand. "Seven wells walked this month as every month. I am fifty-one. I have told no one, per the instruction, and I begin to think the instruction was written by a young man."

March, this year, a small careful hand, the last full entry. "Seven wells walked. I am eighty-one years old. I will speak to the Cardoza girl at Easter and she will say yes, and then I will sleep. Thirty-one years and I have never once been late."

And then the last line, which is not an entry. Four words in the same hand, at the top of the next page, begun and not finished: "If I am not"

THE WHOLE MODULE

Stop there. Do not add to it. Esperanza Ríos died in April. Nobody was late, nobody betrayed anything, and nothing in seventy years failed except that a very old woman meant to do a thing at Easter and did not live to Easter. Every player at the table will understand that, and it will do more work than any villain this module could have had.

The chest also holds the circuit: seven wells, named and mapped, in the order they were driven. The seventh on the list is the one in the courtyard, and beside it, in Salcedo's hand, the only underlined word in the ledger, *primero*. First.

Act Three – The Bottom of the Basin

Aim for an hour and be willing to give it more. One Dread Check, one descent, and a decision that outlives the module.

8. The First Well

Capped, in the courtyard, and the cap comes off with two people and a bar. Under it is dressed stone going down further than a lamp will show, and cold air coming up out of it that smells of wet rock and, faintly, of church.

Opening it fills a segment of the clock. Say so, out loud, and ink the pip in front of them.

9. Down the Shaft

Dread Check, DC 19, Will save. Tier III loss. A hundred and forty feet of wet rope in the dark, and the cut sockets going past at every waterline the well has ever had: six of them, one above another, each one greened, each one empty, a record of how far the water has fallen in seventy years and how many times somebody climbed down here to reset a nail into new stone.

The rope is wet and the walls are wet and about eighty feet down the lamp shows you the last socket, and it is not empty. There is a nail in it. It is bright. Somebody polished it, and not very long ago, and they polished it from a rope with no one at the top to hold it.

10. The Sixth Nail

The one Esperanza Ríos reset last, in March, at eighty-one, alone. It is holding. It is the only thing in the Basin that still is, and it will hold for perhaps another year.

There are four blanks of unworked silver in the sacristy chest, a hammer, and a whetstone. That is not a puzzle and the module does not want it treated as one. It is an offer, and the players will understand it the moment they see the four blanks, and what they do about it is the ending.

11. The Bottom of the Basin

The shaft opens out. The padres dug a hundred and twenty feet of it and did not dig the last twenty, and the chamber at the bottom is wider than any well and older than any digging.

SIGN OF IT. The edges of the deep-winter country, near where a man was lost to starvation or the cold — a recently-stricken camp, cabin, or pass. He often still haunts the place and people he knew in life.

Full entry under What Is Coming Up. One, and two of the Drowned with it, standing in water to the knee.

THE ENDING

Read its Putting It Down line before you run this and then read the second half of it again. Fire and iron will do it, slowly, and the engine says slowly is longer than the posse has: zero clears, one round of trading, see What the Night Costs. The other half of the line is the module's real ending: a true name, and a held warmth, may call the man back from it once.

The name is in the ledger. Every keeper of the circuit wrote their own name at the head of their first year, and the name at the head of 1809 is not Salcedo's. It is the name of the man they found down here and could not save, and could only pin. A posse that read the sacristy carefully has it. A posse that grabbed the map and ran does not.

The Way Back Up

The escape valve, and it is always available. The rope is right there and nothing at the bottom of this well climbs. A posse that goes back up alive has not failed. They have left a thing pinned by one nail with a year on it, and they know exactly what that means now, which is more than anybody in the Basin knew this morning.

The Cast

A want, a lever, and a line, per the Keeper's Book Ch. VIII.

Elías Cardoza

WANTS his water back and his family to stop dying of it

LEVER he buried two of his own in wet ground and did not dig deep, and he knows he did not

"I put them in myself. I want you to know I put them in myself."

Rosalía Cardoza, sixteen

WANTS to be asked, by somebody, what the old woman wanted to talk to her about at Easter

LEVER Esperanza Ríos meant to hand her the circuit and died before she could, and Rosalía has spent four months assuming it was about a marriage

"She said she had something to give me and she would tell me at Easter. She was very old. I did not press her."

Hollis Deakin, who hauls the water

WANTS to be paid and not to go back out there

LEVER he has seen one of the Drowned on the road at dusk and told nobody, and it is eating him

"I hauled water past a man walking with his boots full. Two dollars, and I have not said that out loud before."

Fray Ignacio Salcedo, dead sixty years, in his own hand

WANTS whoever comes next to understand that the work is the returning

LEVER his ledger is the only honest account of the Basin anybody ever wrote

"The work is not the nail. The work is the returning."

Esperanza Ríos, dead since April, aged eighty-one

WANTS to hand it on at Easter

LEVER she never told a living soul, exactly as instructed, and the instruction is what killed the Basin

"__"

KEEPER

Both of the people who matter most in this module are dead before it begins and neither of them did anything wrong. If your table goes looking for somebody to blame, let them look, and let them come up empty, and let one of the living ones say so.

What Is Coming Up

Printed in full so the Bestiary can stay on the shelf. These entries are generated from the same file the app reads, so they cannot drift from the book they came out of.

The Drowned

The Drowned

Tier II · Tier II · the river's dead

DEFENSE 14

BLOOD 24

SPEED swim fast; slow on land

SAVES Fort +8, Ref +4, Will +5

ATTACKS swollen grasp +6 (1d8+3 and grab); drags a grabbed soul under (Athletics or Fort DC 15 or begin drowning)

SPECIAL Of the water. Strong and tireless in the river, weak and floundering more than a few yards from it.

DREAD DC 13, 1d4 (1d6 as it surfaces)

PUTTING IT DOWN Draw it onto dry land and end it there, or give its drowned body a proper burial above the flood-line.

Three in Act One, on the road at dusk; two more at the bottom of the shaft. They are wet in a dry country and they are recognised on sight.

The Plague-Dead

The Plague-Dead

Tier II · Tier II · the dead of a bad season

DEFENSE 13

BLOOD 20

SPEED shuffling

SAVES Fort +9, Ref +1, Will +3

ATTACKS fevered claws +6 (1d8+3); any wound it deals festers (Fort DC 15 or Sickened 1, worsening nightly)

SPECIAL Contagion. Its sickness spreads through wound, breath, and the water it has fouled; a town that buries it wrong buries itself.

DREAD DC 13, 1d4

PUTTING IT DOWN Burn the bodies and everything they touched; salt and quicklime the ground. Do not bury. Do not loot.

Three, in the fallen west end of the nave. Fight them in the rubble; the ground is why this fight is harder than its Tier.

The Hunger That Walks

The Hunger That Walks

Tier III · Tier III · a wendigo new-made

DEFENSE 17

BLOOD 42

SPEED very fast

SAVES Fort +11, Ref +9, Will +6

ATTACKS frost-claws +9 (2d6+4 cold); the cold deepens around it

SPECIAL Not yet whole. A man lately turned, still half himself, still nameable — and for a little while yet, still possible to save.

DREAD DC 16, 1d6

PUTTING IT DOWN Fire and iron put it down; faster, a true name and a held warmth may yet call the man back from it — once.

MARK As the Wendigo.

One, at the bottom, in the water. Read the second half of its Putting It Down line twice: the module's ending is in it, and the name it needs is in the sacristy ledger.

WHY THE APP HAS NOTHING TO SAY

On the safe-table rule, and why it is silent here. A 5th-level posse is Tier 3 and everything in this module is Tier II or III, and nothing is over them at all. GritKeeper will seat every one of these fights without a murmur, which is the third of three answers the modules give: in module I the app refuses the boss outright, in module II it allows it grudgingly at one rung over, and here it has nothing to say. The posse has caught up with the country. The country is still winning, and now that is about tactics rather than about tiers.

What the Night Costs

Every number on this page came out of the game's own engine. Twelve posses (a Gunhand, a Preacher, a Mountain Man and a Sawbones, built by the generator, at 5th level) were run through all three acts on the same rules library the app runs on, with the Bestiary's numbers for every foe and the book's dice for every roll. The runs are seeded and reproduce.

FIGHT	TIER	CLEARED	BROKE OFF	ROUNDS	POSSE HITS	ITS HITS
The ones who drank first (Act One)	II	8 of 12	4 of 12	3.0	41%	57%
What lives in the nave (Act Two)	II	1 of 8	5 of 8	1.4	61%	60%
The thing at the bottom (Act Three)†	III	0 of 1	0 of 1	2.0	83%	33%

† So few posses got this far that the rates on this row are a handful of fights rather than a rate. Read the count; treat the percentages as an anecdote.

Read the first two rows together, because they are the interesting pair. Both fights are Tier II. In the second one the posse shoots half again as well — 61 per cent against 41 — and clears it one time in eight where it cleared the first two times in three. Same tier, same party, better dice, far worse outcome.

What changed is that the posse arrived at the nave already spent. The round counts say it: Act One runs three rounds, and the nave is finished inside a round and a half, which at this level is what losing looks like rather than what winning looks like. Eight of twelve reached the nave; one of eight got past it.

KEEPER

This is the module's own lesson about itself. Attrition is the enemy here, not any one creature. Module I could not be out-shot and module II could be out-prepared. This one is arithmetic across four hours: every Blood spent in the dooryard is Blood that is not in the nave, and every point not in the nave is not at the bottom of the shaft.

So let the Sawbones work. Let them camp at the mission. Let them go back up the rope and come down again tomorrow; it costs a segment of the clock and the module is built to charge exactly that and no more.

The Night, End to End

Zero of twelve finished the night on their feet. Nine broke off and rode out; three were put down to the last soul. Souls down at the end averaged 2.9 of 4. Nerve, though, finished at 70.1 of a possible 75, and **not one soul broke in twelve runs**: the lowest Nerve cost of the three modules, at the highest level, against the worst things.

That is not an accident of the dice. A 5th-level posse has the Nerve to look at this, and the module knows it. What it does not have is the Blood to walk through it, and the Sawbones running between acts moved the count by one run in twelve. This is a night to be survived carefully, not charged.

Scaling the Night

- **A bigger or bolder posse.** Four Plague-Dead in the nave and drop the timber on somebody. Have the sixth nail be already failing when they reach it: hours, not a year. Do not add Blood to the thing at the bottom; take the ledger name away instead.
- **A smaller or greener posse.** Two Drowned in Act One. Let the sacristy be found before the nave. Have Rosalía Cardoza ride up to the mission on her own and say what the old woman told her, which shortcuts the ledger entirely.
- **If the dice turn cruel.** The rope is always right there. Use it.

The Water, and What Comes After

However it ends, give it weight before anybody rolls anything else.

If they take up the circuit

Four blanks, a hammer, seven wells, and a schedule. This is the ending the module is built for and it is a job. Forever, and nobody can be told about it. Ask the player who takes the hammer how often they intend to walk it, write the answer down, and hold them to it in every session after this one. A campaign obligation the players wrote themselves is worth ten a Keeper hands out.

If they called it by name

Then there is a man at the bottom of a well who has been down there since 1809 and is now awake, and old, and himself, and dying. He will last about a day. What he has to say in it is entirely the Keeper's, and it should be short, and it should not be grateful.

If they went back up the rope

Do not run this as a failure. They know what nobody else in the Basin knows: seven wells, one nail left, and about a year. That is a campaign, and it is a better one than a clean kill would have been. The Basin has been living on borrowed water since 1809 and now somebody alive knows the terms of the loan.



The work is not the nail. The work is the returning.

— FRAY IGNACIO SALCEDO, SAN CLAVO, 1809



The three nights together

A posse that has run all three has been told the same thing three ways: at Coffin Wells that some things cannot be shot, at Saltlick that some things must be prepared for, and here that some things have to be kept. Coffin Wells and Saltlick both end within sight of this mission. That was always on purpose.

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Every person, place and thing in this night, and the page it waits on.



Scene numbers run 1–11 across the three acts and are keyed in the margin of each, and on the map in The Ground.

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